literary project of the time that did not meet with his benefaction.[54] By 1901, he had showed political inclinations by chairing the reception committee of the Madurai Political Conference presided over by the nationalist P. Anandacharlu. Though we know little about his early politicization, he was soon drawn to the Swadeshi movement. As a Tamil scholar and editor of *Vivekabhanu*, VOC's association with him may have dated back to 1900. Such was the respect that VOC commanded, that the police reported that VOC had 'an unknown hold over him [Pandithurai Thevar]'.[55] Pandithurai Thevar's (Figure 4) position—as president, officiating secretary and director—demonstrates that he had invested heavily in the company. As we shall see, he remained a pillar of support against the greatest odds, bankrolling the company even as it hurtled to its end. He commanded much respect given his stature as member of the Ramnad royal family and an affluent zamindar and patron of the arts. How much of this respect was convertible into share capital was questionable, though that did not stop him from getting his feet dirty by going to the field to canvass for shares. Fortunately for him, the government did not suspect him of disloyalty though the CID police kept a close tab on him. 'Pandithurai Thevar, a cousin (and a hated one) of the Raja of Ramnad … is connected with the Steam Navigation Com but, as far as I know, his conduct has never been objectionable from a political point of view.'[56]